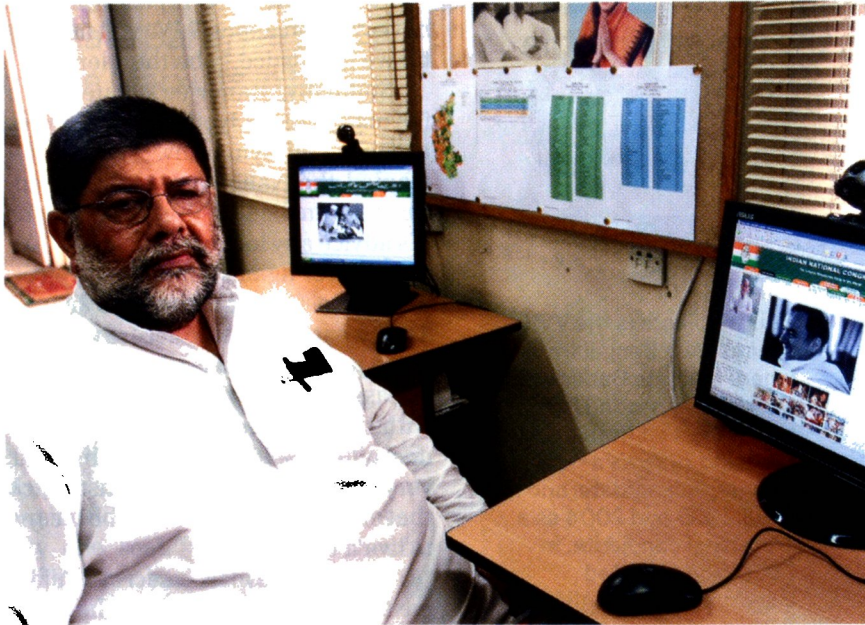


TRAFFICSPOTTING



VISHVJIT SINGH SAYS THE YOUTH ARE BEING DRAWN TO THE CONGRESS THROUGH ITS SITE

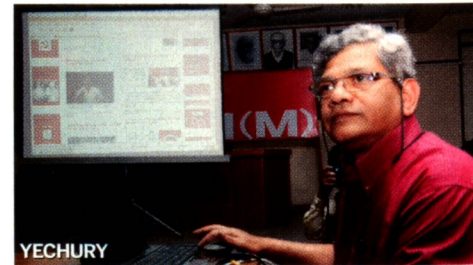
The war for votes is not just being fought on the ground but also in cyberspace. First it was the octogenarian L.K. Advani who fired the first salvo when he launched his website last November, hardselling himself as the BJP's prime ministerial candidate. As a result, the Congress was forced to go in for a rapid makeover of its website. Though the revamped site was relaunched in mid-March, it struggled to match the hype of Advani's portal. But that was till the elections began. Suddenly, the Congress tech team noticed that a day before each polling day, there was an unprecedented surge of visitors to their site that overshoot the traffic to Advani's and the BJP's sites. "It is obvious that the voter is seeking information about the Congress immediately prior to casting of vote. He also conversely loses interest in Advani and the BJP at this crucial time," says Vishvjit Prithvijit Singh, chairman of the Congress computer department. He rattles off statistics from Alexa, the international website monitoring portal to support his argument. Alexa measures and ranks the daily traffic at each site, with the best being at number one. In other words, the lower the figure, higher the rank. According to this data, on April 15, a day before the first phase, the Congress ranked 8,896 while Advani's site was at 47,044 and the official BJP site fell below 1,00,000. Interestingly, Advani's site overshoot the Congress the very next day but again fell behind on April 22 (before the second phase) where the Congress ranked 38,886 and Advani's site stood at 54,377. Similarly, a day before the third phase on April 29, the Congress site ranked 20,048 while Advani was placed at 34,258. This time even the official BJP site overtook Advani's with a ranking of 28,869. An elated Singh says, "It's usually the youth and the corporate sector who access the web. So is there a hidden youth wave that we are all unaware of?" He would be hoping that this interest is not a one-night stand but an affair that lasts till the ballot box.

by Priya Sahgal

Forked TONGUE

CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat's strident and consistent response to joining any future Congress-led government has so far been a political turn-off for the Grand Old Party. "We are for a non-Congress secular government," he says. Even before Rahul Gandhi sent out an open invitation to the Left, Karat's Politburo colleague Sitaram Yechury contradicted him when he told the media in Kolkata, "There is no question of supporting the Congress or anything else during the election campaign. It will be

SIPRA DAS



discussed and decided after the polls since the final theatre will unfold only then." Yechury's comment is untimely at the very least and traitorous at worst. Unlike Karat who ruled out any support to a future Congress Government, Yechury, with his comments has kept the door half open for the Congress. The real story, however, will unfold when the Politburo meets in Delhi on May 18 after the results are announced.

by Shafi Rahman